

PROPOSAL

Annasaheb Shinde Foundation for Agro & Social Development

Empowering Women and Marginal Farmers through Sustainable Livelihoods

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Executive Summary:

This proposal presents the Annasaheb Shinde Foundation's high-impact livelihood enhancement initiative to empower marginal farmers and women-led households through structured and sustainable goat rearing.

This innovative livelihood initiative is especially developed to address the agrarian distress in Maharashtra's tribal and marginalized districts of Nandurbar and Dhule, by offering farmers an alternative and sustainable means of livelihood. The project aims to uplift small and marginal farmers from cycles of poverty and debt by promoting goat rearing—a culturally rooted practice strengthened with scientific breeding, nutrition, healthcare, and market linkages.

The proposal also outlines the Foundation's deep community engagement and current interventions, and strategic partnerships with government agencies to ensure long-term viability. We are ready to take the project to the next level, and seek donor support to expand outreach and implement additional interventions, with the ultimate goal of transforming farmer livelihoods through sustainable and scalable goat-rearing ecosystems that provide stable incomes and an improved quality of life.

The initiative directly contributes to rural development, women's empowerment, nutrition, and livelihood enhancement, while aligning with key Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs 1, 2, 5, and 8).

About the Organization:

The Annasaheb Shinde Foundation (ASF) is a Section 8 Non-Profit Organization committed to sustainable development and economic empowerment in rural India. Its mission is to enhance livelihoods of small and marginal farmers, particularly women and nomadic communities, through structured agricultural and livestock-based interventions.

The Foundation carries forward the legacy of the late Annasaheb Shinde, respected Parliamentarian and Father of India's Green Revolution, whose vision was to transform agriculture into a source of stability and dignity for rural families.

Annasaheb Foundation's work has received endorsements from the District Collectors of Nandurbar (an Aspirational District) and Dhule, validating the credibility and local relevance of its initiatives.

Project Overview:

India is an agrarian economy, with nearly half the population dependent on agriculture for livelihood. Agriculture contributes to **15% of our GDP,** and yet, **s**mall and marginal farmers continue to struggle with low productivity, poor incomes, and increasing vulnerability. Many rely on livestock, especially goats, as a support system.

Farmer Suicide – A Stark Reality:

For countless farming families, the struggle goes far beyond poor harvests—it is a daily battle with debt, climate shocks, and unstable market prices that push them into a cycle of despair. Between 1995 and 2018, India tragically lost over 400,000 farmers to suicide, translating into 48 suicides every day. Between 2018 and 2022, 4,248 farmers died by suicide in Maharashtra alone, accounting for **15% of the total number in of Farmer suicides in India.** Every statistic offers a tragic story – of hardship, helplessness, broken families and communities left vulnerable.

While government schemes provide some relief from debt, they often fall short of addressing the root problem—farmers lack sustainable, resilient livelihood options other than agriculture alone. This is especially critical for small and marginalized farmers—owning less than two acres of land—where agricultural produce is barely sufficient for subsistence, leaving little to no scope for profit.

There is an urgent need for alternative and sustainable livelihood models that can stabilize farmer incomes and reduce dependence on uncertain crop cycles.

Proposed Solution: Structured and Sustainable Goat Rearing:

Recognizing the potential of Goat-based livelihoods to ensure food security and steady household income, the project aims to build a structured Goat Rearing model. The project is designed not just to improve the ecosystem of goat rearing in Maharashtra, but also to strengthen community resilience, promote women's participation in income generation, and build sustainable models of rural entrepreneurship.

Goat: Poor Man's Cow: India is the **world's largest producer of goat milk** and home to **150 million goats**. Goats are often termed the *"poor man's cow,"* are resilient and multipurpose (milk, meat, manure). And yet, goat farmers remain economically marginalized. A number of challenges hinder the farmer in creating a sustainable income from Goat rearing, such as,

- High mortality of kids due to poor healthcare.
- Low milk yields due to weak indigenous breeds.
- Lack of market linkages for goat milk and manure.
- Nomadic lifestyles preventing access to education and healthcare.

The Goodness of Goat Milk: Goat milk has multiple uses, often not known to the General populace, such as,

- **Closest to Human Milk** – Easily digestible, rich in oligosaccharides (good for infants).
- **High Nutrition Value** – Packed with vitamins (A, D, B12) and minerals (calcium, phosphorus, magnesium).
- **Lower in Lactose** – Suitable for people with mild lactose intolerance.
- **Disease Resistant–** Supports recovery in tuberculosis, has antidiabetic & anticancer properties.
- **Good Health Drink** – Strengthens immunity and overall well-being.
- **Cosmetic Uses** – Improves skin health; rich in lactic acid, vitamins, and minerals.

This untapped potential, if harnessed, can become a reliable source of income, nutrition, and empowerment for rural families.

Annasaheb Shinde Foundation's Approach:

To overcome these challenges, Annasaheb Shinde Foundation has developed a systematic approach to goat-based livelihood.

Overall Goal: To transform the lives of small and marginal farmers, particularly women and nomadic communities, by building sustainable and scalable goat-rearing ecosystems that provide stable incomes and improved quality of life.

Objectives:

1. To increase milk yield and productivity of indigenous goat breeds by providing nutrition, infrastructure, and healthcare for goats.
2. To establish direct market linkages for goat milk, meat and manure sales, enhancing the income generation
3. To ensure financial empowerment of women by ensuring greater participation in all processes of Goat Rearing

The Annasaheb Shinde Foundation (ASF) model is not just about animal rearing but about creating a holistic livelihood system where families, especially women, gain long-term stability and self-reliance. By combining breed improvement, market access, and social development, ASF ensures that goat rearing evolves from a subsistence activity into a sustainable enterprise.

Project Focus:

Geographical Area: Malpur in Nandurbar (tribal, aspirational district) which has extremely high levels of poverty

Beneficiary Profile: Nomadic and marginal farmers in tribal and nomadic communities

Why Zalawadi Goat?

ASF promotes the Zalawadi goat, an indigenous breed from Gujarat, reared in North Maharashtra for over 150 years. The breed is known for:

- High milk yield – 2–2.15 kg/day over a 200-day lactation cycle per year
- Good body weight – Males 40 kg, Females -34 kg.
- Strong reproduction rates – 55% twins, 2% triplets, with an average kidding interval of - 11 months.
- Adaptability – Thrives across diverse Indian climates.
- Longevity – Average lifespan of about 12 years.

With its resilience and productivity, the Zalawadi goat offers farmers a dependable and sustainable source of milk, meat, and income, making it the cornerstone of ASF's goat-rearing model.

Focus on Women and Women led households:

A huge majority, that is 93% of the flock owners would be women and women-led households. Women are often the backbone of the sector: they are skilled and dedicated caregivers of the flock, familiar with every aspect of the flock management. They are also often the worse sufferers in an agrarian crisis. The project places women in the heart of the initiative, and also empowers them to lead every stage of the process, from goat rearing to becoming entrepreneurs in their own right.

The ASF Interventions in strengthening Goat Rearing:

1. **Nutrition and Water:** Subsidised fodder, balanced meals, and clean water supply
2. **Healthcare:** Regular vet access, deworming, disease prevention & vaccination
3. **Infrastructure:** Hygienic sheds, dedicated feeding/resting areas, hygienic milking practices
4. **Breeding and Genetics:** Use of superior males Goats, scientific breeding for stronger stock using Artificial Insemination (AI) techniques
5. **Income through Goat Manure:** Goat Manure collection system for additional earnings
6. **Market Linkages:** Establishing Market linkages of buyers and vendors for meat and milk of Goats

Key Productivity Gains

Through focused interventions in breed improvement, health management, and nutrition, the goat-rearing ecosystem has witnessed significant gains in productivity and efficiency.

- The number of deliveries has improved, moving from just **one delivery per year to as many as three within a span of two years.**
- Mortality rates have been successfully reduced **by nearly 50%,** ensuring healthier flocks and greater sustainability.
- The average number of kids born per delivery has increased from **two to between two and three,** boosting overall herd growth.
- Milk yield has shown a **steady rise of 15–20%,** creating better income opportunities for farmers.

Outcomes and Impact:

The project is designed to deliver immediate, measurable benefits for farmers and their communities, while also laying the foundation for long-term systemic change that ensures sustainability, empowerment, and rural prosperity.

Immediate Outcomes:

1. **Improved livestock productivity:** Strengthening indigenous goat breeds leading to healthier animals, reduced mortality, and higher milk yield.
2. **Enhanced farmer income:** Farmers gain sustained earnings through increased milk production and supplementary income from manure.
3. **Job Creation:** creation of a diverse range of jobs across the goat-rearing value chain—from animal care, feed production, and veterinary services to dairy processing, product distribution, and rural enterprise support—driving sustainable livelihoods for communities
4. **Increased participation of women in income generation:** more women participate in all the processes of milk production to sale thereby helping sustained income to women led households

Long term impact:

7. **Sustainable Goat Farming Ecosystem**: A structured and scientifically managed goat-rearing system is established, enabling farmers to achieve stability and long-term livelihood security.
8. **Rural Revitalization & Community Well-being:** Settled farmers contribute to better nutrient and health, regular access for education for children and improved lifestyle
9. **Women Empowerment:** Improvement in women's role and leadership in financial management and decision making in household and community, leading to greater awareness of their rights

Strategic Partnerships with Stakeholders:

1. **MAFSU (Maharashtra Animal & Fishery Sciences University):** Leads technical, social, and commercial protocols; designs health, feed, and genetic programs; coordinates with state, central, and international authorities.

2. **ICAR–CIRG:** Provides national-level research and conservation; supports Goat breed improvement, elite buck distribution, and technology demonstrations.

3. **AHD (Animal Husbandry Department, Maharashtra):** Provides execution support of Central and State government policies to the farmers along with, government resolutions, subsidies, and official committees.

4. **District Collectors (Dhule & Nandurbar):** District Collectors are administrative body for implementation on livelihood requirements at the district level

5. **BAIF (Bharatiya Agro Industries Foundation):** BAIF, as a nonprofit organization that implements advanced technologies at the community level through government support, CSR partnerships, and project-based funding. Its work includes providing farmers with hands-on training in animal husbandry and agriculture.

6. **IGBDPL (Indigenous Goat Breed Development Pvt. Ltd.)** – Oversees the commercial execution of the project, including goat milk collection, processing, cold chain management, feed supply, and establishing farmer market linkages.

7. **AJAMESH** – AJAMESH, an affiliated enterprise of ASF, focuses on auxiliary income streams beyond milk, such as manure, urine pesticides, and organic by-products, while also supporting connectivity with goat flock owners for collection and distribution.

The Annasaheb Shinde Foundation serves as the vital link for the conversion of the programs and initiatives of government and non-government agencies involved in the goat-rearing ecosystem, acting as the on-ground social implementer.

Animal monitoring system:

To establish a robust monitoring and evaluation system, ASF has introduced a method of tagging each animal in the flock with a unique ID, along with the details of the flock owner. This system ensures systematic tracking and coordination across all stages of goat rearing, covering:

- **Disease Prevention:** Timely vaccinations and deworming
- **Medical Care:** Veterinary services and regular health check-ups
- **Health Tracking:** Periodic monitoring of goat progress to identify illness early
- **Nutrition:** Provision of balanced and nutritious fodder
- **Reproduction:** Monitoring of pregnancy, lactation, and safe childbirth practices

- **Kid Care:** Ensuring healthy growth and development of kids
- **Milking Practices:** Hygienic methods for milking, with daily records of yield (twice a day)
- **Milk Quality:** Testing at every draw to maintain standards
- **Genetic Improvement:** Use of artificial insemination (AI) for better yield
- **Breeding Monitoring**: Tracking AI outcomes to ensure high success rates
- **Mortality Tracking:** Monitoring mortality rates within each breed

Right now, this is a manually driven system, but we are on our way to digitally integrate it. This system will help us strengthen animal health management, enhances productivity, and ensures transparency at every stage of goat rearing.

Implementation Plan with Timeline:

Phase	Focus	Key Activities
Phase 1: Backward Integration (Year 1 & 2)	Ground Work: Health, Feed, Genetics, Breeding Training, Social Support	- Selection and tagging of good goat breeds with records. - Regular health check-ups, deworming, vaccinations, veterinary care. – Feed analysis and supply chain establishment. - Hygienic goat sheds. - Training women farmers in management, Artificial Insemination, and breeding support. - Pregnancy and delivery support, newborn (kids) care.
Phase 2: Milk Enhancement & Processing (Year 2 & 3)	Production: Milk, Urine, Manure	- Training of farmers in hygienic milking. - Safe collection, quality check, weighing, and transport. - Storage in Bulk Milk Coolers and chilling. - Pasteurization and packaging throuf. - Development of value-added products - Refrigeration and storage for distribution.
Phase 3: Forward Linkage (Year 2 onwards)	Market Linkages: Authentication, Authorization, Marketing Support to create more awareness	- Product certification and approvals. - Branding, marketing, and sales channels. - Promotion via local shops, fairs, cooperatives, and online platforms. - Building strong distribution networks for milk and by-products.
Long-Term Pillar (Year 3 to 12)	Genetic Improvement	- Gradual breed improvement (disease resistance, higher yield, adaptability).

Journey so Far: Activities Undertaken:

In the first phase, **from 1st Jan 2024 Till 31st May 2025** has initiated a series of strategic interventions to strengthen goat rearing as a sustainable livelihood model.

1. Goat Tagging & Farmer Outreach:

- **Goats Tagged:** 4,000 Goats tagged, from an average of 110 families
- **Geographic Coverage:** 17 villages in 2 districts, impacting 500 people (consisting of flock owners and their families along with goat caretakers and their support staff)
- **Flock Owners:** Identification of new flock owners is ongoing. Activity to intensify post monsoon

2. Job Creation:

- As many as 25 direct jobs were created, like Livestock supervisors, dairy teams, transporters, processing companies, ASF Teams and many others. More to be created post lactation period.

3. Events & Capacity Building:

- **Health Camp:** A series of Summer Health Check-up Camps for goats was organized in March and April, led by MAFSU with a team of 4 expert veterinarians and 4 postgraduate students from Akola. Supported by our field staff of 4 members and two vehicles, the camps were conducted across 17 villages. 90 flock owners (women) participated in it. During the initiative, health cards were prepared for over 3,000 goats, ensuring systematic health monitoring and care for the flocks.
- **Livestock Supervisor Training:** Up to 10 Livestock Supervisors (LSS) trained to monitor the progress of the Goat rearing
- **Routine Health Monitoring:** Daily visits to flocks for check-ups
- **Project Planning:** Proper Journey Plan created for 110 flocks distributed among 6 Livestock supervisors
- **Village Engagement:** Meetings held in target villages for greater involvement and coordination
- **Regular reviews:** Have regular internal review meetings of teams and stakeholders

4. Infrastructure Development:

A new building has been taken on a long-term lease for the project site with the following facilities:

- **Project Office:** Registration of farmers and overall administration
- **Dairy Section:** Milk collection, pasteurisation, and chilling facilities through private partnerships

- **Training Facilities:**

- Trainer and VIP self-contained rooms
- Two dormitories for staff (self-contained)
- Training / Meeting room with attached VIP meeting area

- Training hall
- Kitchen
- Caretaker quarters

- **Additional Facilities:**
- Distillation room for urine testing and conversion
- Basement office for dairy operations
- Storage area for feed and milk
- Second floor (bare space, available for expansion)
- Open terrace (3rd floor) with storage water tanks

With the systems now in place, the program is well-positioned for the second phase of expansion and greater impact in the coming months.

Next Steps – Plans Ahead:

With the groundwork laid and early milestones achieved, the Annasaheb Shinde Foundation is now poised to scale its goat-rearing initiative to the next level of impact. The focus ahead is on deepening outreach, strengthening systems, and building long-term sustainability for women-led households and marginal farmers.

1. **Post Lactation processes:** Milk pasteurisation and processing of the 4000 tagged Goats, and connecting their families to market

2. **Expansion of Outreach:**
   - Tagging an additional 6,000 goats, directly benefitting more than 600 families, and over 3000 individuals
   - Expanding coverage to 30 villages across two districts within the next two years.
   - Mobilizing and training new flock owners, with special emphasis on women-headed households.

3. **Strengthening human resource for effective implementation:** Appointment of field staff, project coordinators, livestock supervisors, and backend support

4. **Scaling up training and health support services:** Expanding structured training modules and veterinary support systems to improve animal health, productivity, and farmer skills on animal management.

5. **Employment Generation Across the Value Chain:** By creating employment opportunities for women and youth across the goat-rearing ecosystem, we anticipate a surge in indirect jobs during the upcoming lactation period. This will include healthcare specialists, milk collection staff, drivers, dairy employees and their support teams, fodder manufacturers, and processing company staff—altogether generating livelihoods for nearly 200 individuals

Scalability and Sustainability:

With the first phase of the project successfully ongoing, we plan to expand to 30 more villages in 2 districts in the next 2 years.

Moreover, the model combines technology with training, ensuring healthy goats, better yields, and improved income for women-led households and marginal farmers. By focusing on women and youth, it creates community ownership and long-term employment across the value chain. With healthy goats producing more milk, better breeding practices improving the next generation, and market linkages providing steady income, families can reinvest in their flocks, creating a self-sustaining cycle. Since the systems and staff are already established, the initiative can be easily expanded to thousands more goats and many more villages without compromising quality.

CSR for Rural Transformation: Join the Goat Rearing Revolution:

The Annasaheb Shinde Foundation is transforming goat rearing into a sustainable rural enterprise that uplifts farmers, empowers women, and strengthens communities. We invite CSR partners to join hands with the Annasaheb Shinde Foundation in transforming rural livelihoods through structured goat rearing. By supporting this initiative, you will empower marginal farmers, strengthen women-led farmer groups, and create meaningful employment opportunities in some of India's most vulnerable communities. Your partnership will help build critical infrastructure, improve goat health and breeds, and fund laboratories and artificial insemination facilities that ensure long-term sustainability.

Together, we can create awareness, enhance incomes, and make rural prosperity a reality—directly uplifting families and changing lives for generations to come.